dynamics along the Afghanistan-Pakistan border regions and India's covert activities therein. Despite interviews with a host of Indian and Afghan security officials, systematic analysis of various US diplomatic cables, and a plethora of reports by credible media, this section provides an Indian reading of the situation, that is what Indian policymakers thought and planned for. What really happened remains a state secret and shall continue to remain so for decades to come.

For Indian security analysts the fact that former Indian PMs Narasimha Rao, I K Gujral, and Morarji Desai depleted R&AW's offensive capabilities inside Pakistan, is one reason why India never credibly threatened Pakistan using indirect means. Such proclamations of India's incapability because some PMs decades ago wrapped up its covert offensive capabilities does not match the rhetoric of Indian agencies' prowess in Balochistan. Moreover, depleting covert assets (which take years to develop) against ostensible enemies, by a conservative state and politically weak leaders is highly unlikely. That such strategic lethargy would continue even after the glaring failure of Operation Parakram to meet its objectives is even more inconceivable. This is reflected in Menon's candid assessments of India's covert infrastructure in the region. When quizzed whether India kept its promise of countering Pakistan after the 2008 embassy attacks, Menon answered: 'what goes on covertly between India and Pakistan has gone on for a long time. There is a mythology that India gave up everything during Gujral's time [but] that has never happened, and that goes on'.[117]

The differences within India's bureaucracy in its covert war with Pakistan have been 'tactical' in nature, that is who, when, and how to target, and the scale of the covert strike. There have hardly ever been fundamental differences on whether India should or not fight Pakistan because, as Menon explains, 'you are in a war. It might be a covert war or whatever, but it's there … it's a fact of life with which we have lived for many years'.[118] Afghanistan has been adjunct to this rivalry in differing capacities across time. But just like the blow-hot-blow-cold nature of India-Pakistan bilateral relations, it has not always been used as a launchpad for anti-Pakistan operations. Former deputy NSA Vijay Nambiar (2005–06) similarly asserts that while there is a natural convergence of interests between Afghanistan and India on the Pashtunistan and Balochistan issues, there was 'no active collaboration in any major way' other than broad political support during